

Cars, cars, cars

The earliest cars, or “horseless carriages,” were just carts powered by an engine instead of being pulled by a horse. Many of the first cars used steam engines. The big breakthrough came in 1862, when the Belgian engineer Étienne Lenoir created a car powered by his newly designed “internal combustion” engine, which burned gas inside a cylinder to create the power.



Gasoline-engined car

- **What?** Hippomobile
- **Who?** Étienne Lenoir
- **Where and when?** France, 1863

Lenoir's first car from 1862 had three wheels and was powered by burning gas, which was ignited repeatedly by an electric spark. The next year, Lenoir modified his engine and switched to gasoline as a fuel for a new car, which he named the Hippomobile.

People's car

- **What?** Volkswagen Beetle Model 1300
- **Who?** Ferdinand Porsche
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1938

The Volkswagen Beetle was commissioned as a “people's car”—an inexpensive vehicle that was affordable for everyone. It was

**Volkswagen
Beetle, 1948**



First practical electric vehicle

- **What?** Electric car
- **Who?** William Ayrtton and John Perry
- **Where and when?** UK, 1881

The first practical electric car was a battery-powered tricycle made by the British engineers William Ayrtton and John Perry. Electric cars are now thought of as cars for the future because they create less pollution.



Smaller rear wheel

FAST FACTS

- The first cars were so unreliable that people often took a horse with them when they went driving—just in case the car broke down!
- Cruise control enables cars to keep a steady speed automatically. This technology was created in 1958 by the American inventor Ralph Teetor.



First car on sale

- **What?** Motorwagen
- **Who?** Karl Benz
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1888

In 1888, the German engineer Karl Benz built the first car for sale to the public—the Benz Patent Motorwagen. To show people how well the new car worked, his wife, Bertha, made the first long car trip in it, traveling 111 miles (180km). This car would become a huge success, and Benz was soon selling 600 cars a year.

